

Lake Retba

A West African lake with a bright pink hue during the dry season and very salty water

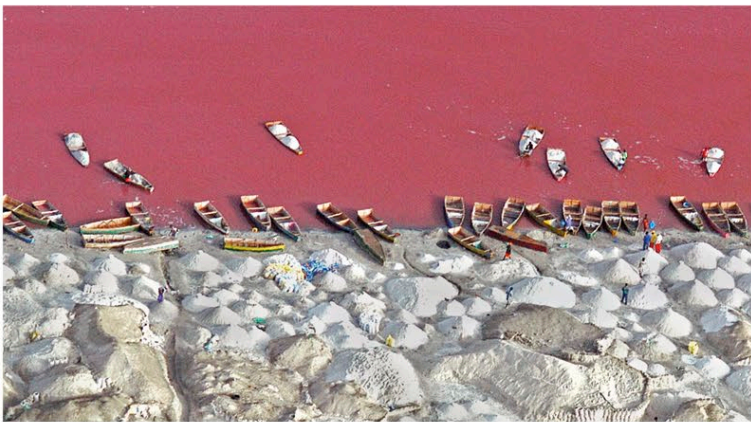


Also called Lac Rose, meaning “Pink Lake” in French, Lake Retba is a small, shallow lake in Senegal, West Africa, best known for its vivid color and the high salt content of its water. The color, which is deeper during the dry season (November to June), is created by an algae species called

Dunaliella salina that produces a red pigment to help absorb sunlight for energy (photosynthesis). The salinity of Lake Retba’s water is comparable to that of the Dead Sea (see p.236), and this has led to adaptations in the lake’s fish, with many growing to only a quarter of the usual adult size.

▷ **SALTY SHORES**

Scores of salt collectors harvest the mineral from the lakebed by hand and export it across West Africa. They cover their skin in shea butter to protect it from the salty conditions.

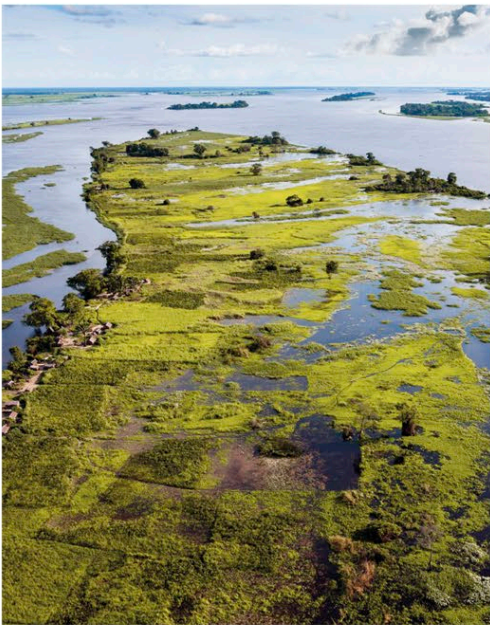


The Congo

One of Earth’s mightiest rivers, draining much of West Africa’s vast tropical rain forest



Africa’s second longest river after the Nile (see pp.190–91), the Congo carries more water to the sea than any other river on Earth except the Amazon (see pp.106–09). It is also the deepest river in the world, with sections reaching more than 660 ft (200 m) deep. From its source in the highlands of Zambia, it flows in a giant counterclockwise arc, draining a vast circular depression that covers most of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, before discharging into the Atlantic Ocean. Its route, which crosses the equator twice, covers more than 2,900 miles (4,700 km) and includes many waterfalls, rapids, broad waterways, and lakes.



▷ **MARSHY BANKS**

For most of its course, the Congo flows through tropical rain forest, where extensive marshes line its banks and run between tributaries.



ENDEMIC FISH

The tropical waters of Lake Malawi are thought to be home to as many as 1,000 species of cichlids, most of which are endemic to the lake.

LAKE MALAWI’S LAYERS

Lake Malawi has a definite stratification, with layers of water having different nutrient and oxygen contents that generally do not mix. However, from May to August, southern parts of the lake experience strong winds and cooling that create a large upwelling of water. This circulation sends nutrients from the mid-depths up the water column to mix with shallow, more oxygenated water, creating ideal conditions for fish to thrive.

